

SONNY'S SHINING

A Novel by Michael Hurley

INSIDE COVER

They called him the best natural talent the lanes had ever seen.

Sonny had the arm, the eye, the instincts—everything a champion needed except the one thing that mattered most: the will to play dirty. In a sport ruled by fixers and phonies, his stubborn honesty made him dangerous. His love for the game made him a target.

And his love for Lucy? That made him a fool.

When the woman of his dreams vanishes into the back of his rival's limousine on New Year's Eve, Sonny does what any heartbroken bowler would do: he tears the city apart to get her back. From smoke-filled bars to rooftop chases, from underground clubs to the deck of a pleasure yacht, he'll face an army of killers, freaks, and monsters—all of them on Kewpie's payroll, all of them standing between Sonny and the woman he loves.

But as the body count rises and the blood on his hands grows harder to wash off, Sonny will discover something terrible: the line between hero and monster is thinner than a bowling lane, and some victories cost more than any trophy is worth.

A fever dream of violence and heartbreak. A tragedy dressed up as a love story. A beat-em-up requiem for a fool who couldn't stop swinging.

PRELUDE

Before the first pin falls...

There's a moment in every bowler's life when the ball leaves your hand and you know—you just *know*—it's going to be a strike. The spin is perfect. The angle is true. The pins are already falling in your mind before the ball even reaches them.

That's how Sonny felt the first time he saw Lucy.

She was standing at the edge of the tournament crowd, red hair catching the fluorescent lights like fire, watching him with eyes that seemed to see right through his mediocre record and straight into his soul. He released his ball without looking. Perfect strike. The crowd went wild.

She smiled.

And Sonny, God help him, smiled back.

That was three months ago. Three months of tournaments and "accidental" meetings, of shared drinks and stolen glances, of falling so hard and so fast that he forgot the first rule of bowling:

Keep your eye on the pins, not the crowd.

Because while Sonny was watching Lucy, someone else was watching too.

Someone with a bowling-pin limousine and an empire built on broken fingers.

Someone who always got what he wanted.

And tonight, on the last night of the year, Kewpie wanted Lucy.

CHAPTER ONE: BUBBLES AND PROMISES

The confetti fell like snow in a city that had forgotten what snow looked like.

Sonny—two-time regional bowling champion, three-time heartbroken fool—watched the little paper diamonds catch the light of Bertie's Bustling Bubbles, the classiest dive on the wrong side of Vine. His fingers were wrapped around a champagne flute he couldn't afford, but tonight, he didn't care about money.

Tonight, he had Lucy.

She laughed at something he'd said—he couldn't even remember what—and her red curls bounced like they were keeping time with the band. The way the light caught her eyes made him forget every gutter ball he'd ever thrown, every trophy Kewpie had stolen from under his nose.

"You know what I love about you, Sonny?" Lucy leaned in close, her perfume cutting through the cigar smoke and spilled bourbon. "You're not like the other bowlers."

"Yeah?" He tried to sound casual, like his heart wasn't doing the Charleston in his chest. "How's that?"

"You actually *care* about the game. Kewpie, he just cares about winning." She made a face like she'd tasted something sour. "About the fame. The money. You? You love the pins. The sound they make when they fall."

Sonny grinned. She understood. God help him, she actually understood.

The clock on the wall showed 11:47. Thirteen minutes to midnight. Thirteen minutes until he'd kiss her, tell her everything he'd been too chickenshit to say for three months of stolen glances at tournaments and "accidental" run-ins at bowling alleys across the city.

The band was playing something slow and sweet. Couples swayed on the dance floor like wheat in a summer breeze. Somewhere, a cork popped, and champagne fountained toward the tin ceiling.

"Dance with me," Lucy said. It wasn't a question.

He took her hand. Warm. Soft. The calluses on his bowling fingers felt like sandpaper against her silk skin, but she didn't seem to mind.

They swayed together, and Sonny closed his eyes, letting himself believe—really believe—that maybe the universe had finally decided to stop treating him like a spare.

That's when he felt her stiffen.

"Lucy?"

Her eyes had gone somewhere else. Past him. Toward the bar, where Bertie—owner, bartender, and all-around greaseball—was polishing a glass with theatrical slowness. The big man caught Lucy's gaze and tilted his head toward the back of the house.

Then he smiled.

Sonny had seen friendlier smiles on loan sharks.

"Lucy, what's—"

"I'll be right back, baby." She patted his cheek, but her hand was cold now. "Just... freshening up."

She slipped through the crowd like smoke through fingers, heading not for the powder room but for the bar. Sonny watched as Bertie leaned over, his lips brushing her ear, whispering something that made her face go pale as bone.

Then she was moving again—faster now—pushing through the door marked "EMPLOYEES ONLY."

And she was gone.

The clock struck 11:52.

CHAPTER TWO: LAST CALL

Sonny stood frozen on the dance floor while couples swirled around him like he was a rock in a river. The champagne in his stomach had turned to lead.

She'll be right back, he told himself. *She said she'd be right back*.

But the way she'd moved. The way her face had changed. The way Bertie was still smiling that snake-oil smile...

He pushed through the crowd, not caring whose drinks he spilled or whose toes he crushed. The bar was a mahogany altar where sinners came to confess, and Bertie was the priest who'd heard it all.

"Where is she?"

Bertie looked up, still polishing that same damn glass. "Who's that now?"

"Don't play dumb with me. Lucy. Where'd she go?"

"Lucy, Lucy..." Bertie scratched his chin like he was trying to remember the name of a second cousin. "Oh, the redhead? Yeah, she asked about the back way out. Something about an old friend picking her up."

The lead in Sonny's stomach turned to ice.

"What old friend?"

Bertie's smile widened until it threatened to crack his face in half. "Drives a real fancy car, this friend. Long and white. Shaped kinda like..." He snapped his fingers. "What's the word? Ah, yeah. A bowling pin."

Kewpie.

Kewpie.

The name hit Sonny like a sixteen-pound ball to the gut. Kewpie, with his slicked-back hair and diamond pinky ring. Kewpie, who'd stolen three championships through bribery and blackmail. Kewpie, who collected women like other men collected stamps, using them up and throwing them away.

Kewpie, who'd been sniffing around Lucy at every tournament, watching her with those hungry little eyes.

"You're lying."

"Am I?" Bertie set down the glass. "Or maybe your girl finally figured out what side of the lane her bread is buttered on. Can't blame her, really. Kewpie's got the trophies. The mansion. The future." He looked Sonny up and down. "What've you got? A worn-out bag and a dream that died three strikes ago?"

The band stopped playing. Or maybe Sonny just couldn't hear them anymore over the blood pounding in his ears.

"Open that door."

"Can't do that, friend. Employees only."

"I'm not your friend."

The clock on the wall clicked. 11:58.

Somewhere in the distance, through the walls, Sonny heard it: a giggle. Lucy's giggle. And then the purr of an engine, big and expensive, pulling away into the night.

He started toward the back door. Bertie moved to block him, all six-foot-four of him, shoulders wide as a delivery truck.

"Don't make this difficult, champ."

"Get out of my way."

"Or what?"

Sonny didn't answer. He was too busy noticing how quiet the bar had gotten. How the waitstaff had stopped serving. How they were all looking at him with the same predatory gleam as their boss.

The clock struck midnight.

Somewhere in the city, fireworks exploded. Champagne corks popped. Lovers kissed.

In Bertie's Bustling Bubbles, a glass bottle shattered against the spot where Sonny's head had been half a second before.

"Happy New Year," Bertie laughed, reaching for another. "Now let's see how good your reflexes really are."

CHAPTER THREE: THE TOWEL

The bottle spun through the air, trailing bourbon and bad intentions.

Sonny's body moved before his brain caught up. Thirteen years of bowling had given him reflexes that most athletes only dreamed of—the ability to read spin, to calculate trajectory, to react in the space between heartbeats.

His hand went to his belt, to the worn leather pouch where he kept his ball-shining towel. The fabric was smooth as silk, embedded with just enough grit to bring out a mirror shine on urethane.

It was also, as it turned out, excellent for catching bottles.

The towel snapped out like a matador's cape, wrapping around the flying glass and redirecting its momentum in a perfect arc. Sonny spun with it, using the bottle's own weight to sling it back at its source.

Bertie's eyes went wide.

The bottle caught him square in the forehead, exploding in a shower of glass and top-shelf whiskey. He staggered back, clutching his face, and Sonny was already moving.

"Get him!" Bertie roared, blood streaming between his fingers. "Don't let him reach the back!"

The waitstaff descended.

They came at him with brooms and serving trays, with chair legs and cocktail shakers. Sonny ducked the first swing, sidestepped the second, caught a flying ashtray with his towel and whipped it into the kneecap of the bruiser coming up on his left.

The bar had become a war zone. Tables flipped. Glasses shattered. The remaining patrons scrambled for the exits, screaming, while the New Year's Eve party transformed into something far more primal.

Sonny fought like a man possessed.

A waitress came at him with a broken bottle. He caught her wrist, twisted, felt the glass clatter to the floor. An elbow to her solar plexus and she was down.

Two bartenders rushed him from behind the bar, wielding soda guns like weapons. The carbonated stream hit him in the face, blinding him momentarily, but he'd bowled in worse conditions. His towel found a wine bottle on a nearby table, and he sent it spinning into the first bartender's teeth.

The second one got close enough to grab him by the collar. Sonny headbutted him, felt the satisfying crunch of cartilage, and shoved him backward into the bar mirror.

Seven years of bad luck.

He was almost to the back door when something hit him from behind—a full champagne bucket, ice and all. He went down hard, stars exploding across his vision.

Bertie loomed over him, face a mask of blood and rage.

"You're not the first lovesick fool who's tried to play hero in my bar," the big man growled. He was holding a magnum of champagne by the neck, the most expensive weapon Sonny had ever seen. "You won't be the last. But you *will* be an example."

The magnum started its descent.

Sonny's hand closed around a chunk of ice, and he threw it—not at Bertie, but at the ceiling fan directly above him.

The ice hit the spinning blade and ricocheted at an angle even Sonny couldn't have calculated. It struck the chandelier chain. The chandelier dropped.

Bertie looked up just in time to catch four hundred pounds of crystal and brass directly on his skull.

The impact drove him to his knees. The magnum slipped from his fingers. And Sonny was up, grabbing a fallen mop handle, swinging it like a Louisville Slugger.

The crack of wood on bone echoed through the suddenly silent bar.

Bertie went down.

Sonny stood over him, chest heaving, blood from a dozen small cuts mixing with sweat on his face.

"Where's the limo going?"

Bertie spat out a tooth. "You think... you can stop him? Kewpie owns this city. Owns every alley, every lane, every pin from here to the harbor."

"I didn't ask what he owns. I asked where he's going."

"To hell," Bertie laughed. "And he's taking your girl with him."

Sonny looked around. The bar was destroyed. Bodies lay groaning among the wreckage. Through the broken windows, he could see the flashing lights of police cars, still blocks away but getting closer.

He didn't have time for this.

But he had time for one thing.

CHAPTER FOUR: TAKING OUT THE TRASH

The trash can was industrial-sized, the kind used by restaurants that expected to throw away a lot of evidence. Sonny dragged Bertie toward it, the big man's heels leaving trails in the spilled liquor and broken glass.

"Wait," Bertie groaned. "Wait, wait—we can talk about this—"

Sonny wasn't interested in talking.

He lifted Bertie by the belt and collar, ignoring the man's flailing limbs, and brought him down hard on the open rim of the trash can. The impact forced the air from Bertie's lungs in a wheezing gasp.

Again. And again.

Each impact folded the bartender a little more, his body compressing like an accordion being slowly collapsed. His legs kicked weakly. His arms scraped at the metal.

By the fifth slam, he was bent nearly in half.

The trash can swallowed him with a wet, meaty sound.

Sonny grabbed the handles and wheeled his prize toward the back door, past the destruction, past the groaning wounded, into the alley behind Bertie's Bustling Bubbles.

The night air hit him like a slap—cold, clean, carrying the distant sound of fireworks and drunken singing. The alley was narrow and dark, lined with dumpsters and fire escapes, the kind of place where bad decisions came to die.

He tipped the trash can on its side and sent it rolling down the alley, Bertie's muffled screams echoing off the brick walls.

It hit a dumpster with a clang that would wake the dead.

Sonny allowed himself one moment—just one—to breathe. His hands were shaking. Not from fear. From adrenaline. From the certain knowledge that he'd just crossed a line that couldn't be uncrossed.

But then he heard it.

Faint, floating on the wind like a ghost: Lucy's laugh.

He looked up and saw her—just for an instant—framed in a window three stories up, across the alley. Her silhouette, unmistakable. Her voice, carried down to him like a taunt.

Then she was gone.

And from the door beside him—the kitchen exit he hadn't noticed—came a sound that made his blood run cold.

Clack. Clack. Clack.

Like something with too many legs moving across a tile floor.

The door burst open, and hell itself scuttled out into the night.

CHAPTER FIVE: SOMETHING CRAWLED OUT OF THE KITCHEN

The thing in the doorway was impossible.

It had to be. Sonny's mind rebelled against it, tried to shove it into a category that made sense. A costume. A prop. A really, really convincing hallucination brought on by too many champagne cocktails and a recent head trauma.

But the smell convinced him otherwise.

It was a crab. A crab the size of a Buick, fire-engine red, its shell gleaming wetly in the moonlight. Eight legs clicked and scraped against the alley cobblestones. Its claws—each one big enough to snip a man in half—flexed with mechanical precision.

And perched atop this nightmare, nestled in a mane of luxurious blonde hair that would have made any starlet weep with envy, was a mouse.

A tiny field mouse with a little toothbrush mustache.

It held what looked like miniature reins connected to the crab's eyestalks, and when it spoke, its voice was high and reedy but carried with surprising force.

"You shouldn't have come back here, friend." The mouse's whiskers twitched. "The kitchen is closed."

The crab snapped its claws, producing a sound like two guillotines practicing their scales.

"Charlie, I presume?" Sonny kept his voice steady, buying time while his eyes scanned for weapons, exits, anything.

"Chef Charlie, if you please." The mouse adjusted something on the crab's head—it looked disturbingly like a bridle. "And this magnificent specimen is my sous chef. We've been together for... oh, seven years now? Eight? Time flies when you're making beautiful cuisine."

"And ugly corpses?"

"One man's corpse is another mouse's mise en place." Charlie giggled, and the crab giggled with him—a horrible bubbling sound that came from somewhere deep in its shell. "But enough pleasantries. You've made quite a mess of our front of house. Bertie was a valued customer. And more importantly..."

The crab began to advance, legs moving in perfect synchronization.

"...you've interrupted my *soufflé*."

Sonny dove sideways as a claw scythed through the space where he'd been standing. It struck a dumpster and went through the steel like paper, spraying garbage across the alley.

He came up running, vault over a pile of broken pallets, looking for anything he could use. His towel was still tucked in his belt, but somehow he doubted it would do much against armored chitin.

"Run, run, run!" Charlie's laughter echoed off the walls. "The exercise will tenderize the meat!"

The crab was fast—faster than something that size had any right to be. It scuttled after him with horrifying efficiency, claws snapping at his heels, leaving gouges in the concrete.

Sonny grabbed a loose brick and hurled it. The crab deflected it with a casual swipe, sending stone fragments flying.

He spotted a fire escape ladder, rusted but sturdy. If he could get high enough—

The crab's claw closed around his ankle.

CHAPTER SIX: CRUSTACEAN CALCULATION

Pain exploded up Sonny's leg as the claw squeezed, not enough to sever but enough to let him know it could.

"Not so fast, monsieur." Charlie steered his mount closer, the crab's eyestalks swiveling to examine its prey. "We haven't even discussed the evening's specials."

Sonny hung upside down, blood rushing to his head, watching the cobblestones spin below him.

Think. *Think*.

He was a bowler. His whole life was about understanding angles, calculating trajectories, finding the perfect point of impact to send pins flying in exactly the right direction.

The crab's shell gleamed in the moonlight. Tough. Armored. But shells had joints. Shells had weak points.

And crabs, despite their impressive appearance, were fundamentally *stupid*.

"Hey, Charlie," Sonny grunted through the pain. "What do you call a crab that plays baseball?"

The mouse frowned. "What?"

"A *pinch* hitter."

Charlie's whiskers twitched in annoyance. "That's terrible. Claude, finish him."

The crab—Claude, apparently—raised its free claw for the killing blow.

Sonny whipped out his towel.

Not at the crab. At the fire escape above him.

The weighted corner wrapped around a rung, and Sonny *pulled*, using the crab's own grip as a fulcrum. His body swung upward in an arc, his free foot connecting with the underside of Claude's claw—right at the joint where chitin met softer tissue.

Claude shrieked—a sound like steam escaping a broken pipe—and the claw spasmed open.

Sonny dropped, rolled, came up running.

But he wasn't running away.

He was running toward the kitchen door.

"Stop him!" Charlie screamed. "He's heading for the—"

Sonny burst through the door into Charlie's Cracking Cantina and found exactly what he was hoping for: a commercial kitchen full of very sharp implements and very nervous staff.

Also, massive stockpots. The kind used for lobster.

"Evening, folks." He grabbed a cleaver from a stunned prep cook. "Anyone know how to boil a crab?"

Behind him, Claude squeezed through the doorway, taking out half the frame, Charlie still clinging to his ridiculous hair like a demented jockey.

The kitchen staff scattered.

Sonny had maybe thirty seconds before he became the night's special.

CHAPTER SEVEN: MISE EN PLACE

The kitchen was a labyrinth of stainless steel and steam.

Sonny wove between prep stations, ducking under hanging pots, vaulting over countertops. Claude followed, his bulk smashing through everything in his path, sending pans and utensils flying.

"You can't run forever!" Charlie's voice echoed off the tiles. "This is *my* domain! Every surface, every tool, every *knife* answers to me!"

As if to prove his point, a cleaver embedded itself in the wall an inch from Sonny's head. He looked back to see a sous chef—eyes glassy, movements jerky—reaching for another blade.

Kewpie's reach extended further than he'd thought. The whole staff was in on it.

Sonny caught the next thrown knife with his towel, redirected it into the shoulder of the thrower. The man went down screaming, and three more took his place.

The industrial stove loomed ahead—eight burners, all blazing, heating the massive stockpots that were the kitchen's signature. Steam billowed toward the ceiling, creating a fog of war that smelled of butter and garlic.

An idea began to form.

"Hey, Charlie!" Sonny yelled over his shoulder. "I've got a question about French cooking!"

"Oh?" The mouse sounded amused, even as Claude's claws demolished a pastry station. "Do tell!"

"What's the difference between a crab and a lobster?"

"Their taxonomy, obviously. Crabs are Brachyura, lobsters are—"

"Wrong!" Sonny reached the stockpot and grabbed the lid. "The difference is, lobsters get cooked *head first!*"

He swung the lid like a discus, not at Claude, but at the burner controls.

All of them.

Every dial snapped to maximum simultaneously.

The stockpots—already simmering—erupted like geysers, sending columns of boiling water toward the ceiling. The steam cloud became impenetrable, scalding hot.

Claude shrieked and reared back, his shell providing protection but his joints and eyes far more vulnerable. He crashed into a rack of pots, sending them cascading down, and Charlie was thrown from his perch, tumbling into a bin of flour.

"Claude! *CLAUDE!*"

Sonny moved through the steam by memory and instinct, counting steps, feeling his way. His hands found the heavy-duty string used for trussing turkeys. Perfect.

The crab was thrashing blindly, claws snapping at nothing, too panicked to defend itself.

Sonny went to work.

CHAPTER EIGHT: THE SPECIAL

When the steam cleared, Claude hung from the pot rack like a grotesque piñata.

Every one of his eight legs was bound together with butcher's twine, pulled tight and tied off in an elaborate bow. His claws were similarly restrained, crossed over his shell in a mockery of surrender. The great red beast swung gently, clicking and bubbling, completely helpless.

Charlie sat in the flour bin, white as a ghost, his little mustache dusted with powder.

"You..." The mouse's voice was barely a squeak. "You can't do this. Do you know who we work for? Kewpie will—"

"Kewpie isn't here." Sonny picked up a stockpot—the largest in the kitchen, the one reserved for the most impressive presentations. "But you are."

He advanced on the suspended crab.

"No," Charlie whimpered. "No, wait—"

The pot wasn't quite big enough. That was the point.

Sonny shoved Claude into it headfirst, the shell scraping against the rim, legs flailing uselessly. He had to push—hard—forcing the crab's bulk into a space too small to contain it. Claude's carapace cracked. His legs snapped. The horrible bubbling shriek rose to a crescendo and then... stopped.

What remained was a pot with too many limbs sticking out of it, leaking fluids that weren't meant to be seen.

Sonny picked up the pot by its handles.

"The back door leads to the alley," he said to the empty kitchen. "And the alley leads to a garbage truck. Any objections?"

No one objected.

The walk to the alley was short. The trash truck—a behemoth with a compactor big enough to crush a car—was making its New Year's Eve rounds, just pulling up to the dumpster at the alley's end.

Sonny wound up like he was preparing for the championship bowl of his life.

And threw.

The pot sailed through the air in a perfect arc, trailing crab juice like a comet's tail. It cleared the fence at the alley's back, descended, and landed with a wet *crunch* in the back of the garbage truck.

The compactor began its cycle.

The sounds that followed were... educational.

When it was over, all that remained was a trail of fluid—pink and viscous—leaking from the truck's seams as it rumbled away into the night.

Charlie, who had followed on trembling legs, stared at the retreating vehicle with hollow eyes.

"You're a monster," he whispered.

"No." Sonny grabbed the mouse by his tail, ignoring the tiny paws scratching at his fingers. "I'm just a guy who wants his girl back. Now—where's the limo headed?"

Charlie squealed as Sonny swung him upside down.

"Talk, or you're joining your friend in the next truck."

CHAPTER NINE: ROOFTOP ANGEL

The mouse talked.

Through chattering teeth and tear-streaked whiskers, he told Sonny everything: Kewpie's route through the city, the stops he'd planned, the layered defenses designed to slow down anyone foolish enough to follow.

"He knew," Charlie sobbed. "He knew you'd come after her. This whole night—it's a game to him. He's been planning it for months."

"Why?"

"Because you embarrassed him." The mouse's eyes darted nervously. "The Southeast Regional, six months ago. You should have lost. The fix was in. But you—you just kept bowling. Kept scoring. Beat him fair and square in front of everyone. Made him look like a fool."

Sonny remembered that night. The way the crowd had chanted his name. The way Kewpie's face had twisted with rage as the final pin fell.

"This isn't about Lucy," he realized. "This is about revenge."

"It's about both." Charlie's voice was barely audible now. "He wants to break you. Take everything you love. And make you watch while he does it."

Sonny dropped the mouse into a nearby drain grate. Charlie's squeaks faded as he disappeared into the sewer system, no doubt to spend the rest of his nights among creatures more his size.

Now—where?

The answer came as a voice, drifting down from above like a song half-remembered.

"—and then he said, 'Honey, that's not my bowling ball!' Can you *imagine*?"

Lucy. Laughing. Telling stories to someone unseen.

Sonny looked up.

There she was, five stories above him, silhouetted against the full moon on some invisible rooftop. Her red hair caught the wind like flames. Her posture was relaxed, casual, as if she didn't have a care in the world.

As if she wasn't being chased by a man who had just murdered a crab the size of a sedan.

"Lucy!" He cupped his hands around his mouth. "*LUCY!*"

For a moment—just a moment—she looked down. Their eyes met across the vertical distance. Something flickered across her face. Recognition? Fear?

Hope?

Then a voice bellowed from above.

"KEEP IT QUIET DOWN THERE!"

A vase shattered at Sonny's feet, spraying ceramic shards across the alley.

He looked up to see a man leaning out of a fourth-floor window—bald, furious, wearing a bathrobe that had seen better decades. His face was twisted with the particular rage of someone whose beauty sleep had been disturbed.

"Some of us are trying to EXIST!" the man screamed, reaching for another vase.

Sonny's eyes traced the fire escape zigzagging up the building's face. It was rusted, rickety, missing more rungs than it had. But it led to the roof.

It led to Lucy.

He grabbed the lowest rung and started climbing.

CHAPTER TEN: DESI'S DARLING DWELLINGS

The fire escape shook with every step, bolts groaning in their sockets.

Sonny climbed hand over hand, trying to ignore the five-story drop beneath him. The cold metal bit into his palms. His arms burned from the night's exertions.

But he kept climbing.

The first object hit him on the second-floor landing. A lamp, cheap and heavy, glancing off his shoulder hard enough to make him lose his grip for one terrifying moment.

"GO AWAY!" The bald man—Desi, presumably, landlord of this crumbling palace—was leaning out his window, surrounded by an arsenal of household items. "THIS IS PRIVATE PROPERTY!"

A toaster followed the lamp. Then a clock radio. Then what appeared to be an entire microwave oven.

Sonny dodged and weaved, using the fire escape's railings as cover. The projectiles rained down like hail, shattering on the metal platforms, bouncing off into the alley below.

"You don't understand!" he shouted up. "I'm looking for someone!"

"And I'm looking for PEACE AND QUIET!" A window-unit air conditioner tore free from its mounting and plummeted past Sonny's head, close enough that he felt the breeze. "NOW GET OFF MY BUILDING BEFORE I CALL THE COPS!"

Sonny climbed faster.

He was at the third floor when the tenants joined in.

Doors opened onto the fire escape landings, and people in various states of undress emerged with the wild-eyed look of the involuntarily awakened. They didn't ask questions. They didn't make demands. They simply began throwing whatever was at hand.

Books. Shoes. Potted plants. A small yapping dog that, thankfully, landed on a lower platform and scampered to safety.

"New year, same bullshit!" an old woman screamed, hurling a brass candlestick that whistled past Sonny's ear. "Can't even have ONE NIGHT without some mook climbing the building!"

The building, Sonny realized, wasn't just run-down. It was *deranged*. Every tenant seemed to have a personal grudge against the concept of visitors.

Kewpie's payroll. Again.

He caught a flying alarm clock with his towel and returned it to sender. The throw caught an elderly man in the chest and sent him toppling back into his apartment.

"Sorry!" Sonny yelled, not slowing down.

Fourth floor. Fifth floor. The roof access ladder was in sight.

And Desi was climbing down to meet him.

CHAPTER ELEVEN: THE LANDLORD'S CLAUSE

Desi blocked the ladder like a bathrobed gargoyle.

"You're on my property." His voice had dropped from screaming to something more dangerous—calm, measured, the voice of a man who had evicted tenants in far more permanent ways. "And I have a very strict no-visitors policy."

Up close, he was bigger than he'd looked. The bathrobe was silk, expensive, embroidered with golden threads. His bald head gleamed with sweat despite the cold.

And in his hand was a coat hanger. Wire. Sharp.

"Just let me pass," Sonny said. "I'm not looking for trouble."

"Trouble found you anyway." Desi stepped forward, the fire escape platform creaking beneath his bulk. "Kewpie said you might come. Said there'd be a bonus for whoever stopped you. Said—"

"I don't care what Kewpie said."

"Then you're stupider than you look." Desi lunged.

The coat hanger swung in a vicious arc aimed at Sonny's throat. He leaned back, felt metal whisper past his Adam's apple, and counterattacked with a palm strike to Desi's solar plexus.

The landlord absorbed the blow like it was nothing.

"My building," Desi growled, "my rules." He grabbed Sonny by the collar and slammed him against the railing. "And Rule Number One is: deadbeats pay with their lives."

The railing bent outward. Sonny felt his feet leave the platform, his body tipping toward the void.

Five stories. Concrete below. It would be quick, at least.

He grabbed Desi's bathrobe and pulled.

If he was going over, he wasn't going alone.

They grappled on the edge of oblivion, two men locked together, gravity waiting patiently for its due. Desi's weight was working against him now—too much mass, too little balance. He tried to pull back, but Sonny held tight.

"Let GO!"

"After you."

Sonny drove his knee upward into Desi's groin. The landlord's grip loosened for just a second, and that was all Sonny needed.

He spun, using the bathrobe as leverage, and whipped Desi around until their positions were reversed—the landlord against the broken railing, Sonny on the relatively solid platform.

"Here's the thing about property rights," Sonny said. He grabbed the coat hanger from Desi's fingers. "They don't mean much when you're dead."

The wire was sharp. Sharper than it should have been—modified, probably, for exactly this purpose.

Sonny shoved it into Desi's open, screaming mouth.

CHAPTER TWELVE: HANGING BY A THREAD

The hook caught something vital on the way down.

Desi gagged, his hands scrabbling at the wire protruding from his lips. Blood bubbled up, dark and viscous, spilling down his chin and spattering on the silk bathrobe.

Sonny didn't watch.

He grabbed the other end of the coat hanger, looped it around the clothesline that stretched across the alley—a relic of more innocent times when people hung their laundry to dry in the city air—and *pushed*.

Desi went sailing.

The clothesline sagged under his weight but held, the hook in his throat providing a grotesque anchor point. He zipped across the gap between buildings, arms pinwheeling, legs kicking, gargling sounds that might have been screams.

Halfway across, the hook ripped free.

Desi plummeted, bouncing off a fire escape on the opposite building, spinning end over end, finally landing with a wet crunch in a dumpster five stories below.

The sound was final. Absolute.

Sonny climbed the last ladder and pulled himself onto the roof.

It was dark up here, and wet—recent rain had left puddles that reflected the city lights like broken mirrors. The party, if there had been one, was long over. Bottles lay scattered. Streamers drooped from makeshift poles.

And Lucy was gone.

Of course she was.

He walked to the edge, looking out over the city he'd thought he knew. It looked different from up here—smaller, somehow, and dirtier. The neon signs that had always seemed magical were just light pollution, drowning out the stars.

Then he heard it.

Club music. Thumping bass that vibrated through the building beneath his feet. And mixed with it, carried on the wind like a promise and a threat: Lucy's giggle.

He traced the sound to its source and saw the club—Bessie's Bouncing Ballroom, according to the flickering sign—across the busy street below. And there, pulling up to the entrance in all its obscene glory, was Kewpie's limo.

The bowling-pin shape was unmistakable even from this height. White and grotesque, stretched beyond any reasonable proportion. The door opened, and a red-haired figure slipped into the back seat.

The limo pulled away, disappearing around a corner.

Sonny looked at the power lines running between his rooftop and the building across the street.

It was insane. It was suicidal. It was exactly the kind of thing a desperate man with nothing left to lose might try.

He pulled out his ball-shining towel and wound the ends around his hands.

"Happy New Year to me," he muttered.

And jumped.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN: FLIGHT OF THE DESPERATE

The power line caught him like a clothesline catches a running child—hard enough to knock the wind from his lungs, burn through his towel, and make him seriously reconsider his life choices.

But it held.

Sonny slid, friction heating the towel until he could smell burning fabric. The street rushed beneath him, cars and pedestrians oblivious to the man ziplining through their night.

He was going to overshoot. The building across the street was coming up too fast, and he had no way to slow down.

So he let go.

For one eternal moment, he was flying—truly flying—arms spread, the city lights blurring around him, the wind screaming past his ears.

Then the window found him.

Glass exploded inward, and Sonny crashed into something soft and screaming.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN: TIPPI'S TANTALIZING TANGO

The screaming, he realized, was coming from multiple sources.

He'd landed on a chaise lounge—leather, expensive, currently occupied by two people engaged in activities that didn't bear close examination. They scrambled away, shrieking, as Sonny rolled off the furniture and onto the floor.

The room was... educational.

Cages hung from the ceiling. Leather straps festooned the walls. Massage tables—if that's what they were—lined the perimeter, occupied by patrons in various states of undress and distress.

And everywhere, *everywhere*, there were heels.

Stilettos as long as daggers. Platforms tall enough to require a safety harness. Pumps with spikes that could puncture steel.

"Well, well, well."

The voice came from the far end of the room, where a woman stood atop a small stage. She was tall—impossibly tall, thanks to shoes that added a good eight inches to her height. Her blonde hair was sculpted into an elaborate tower. Her outfit was leather and lace, revealing and concealing in equal measure.

"An uninvited guest." She smiled, and it was the smile of a snake eyeing a mouse. "I do *love* uninvited guests."

"I'm just passing through," Sonny said, climbing to his feet. "The door's behind you, and I need to be on the other side of it."

"The elevator, you mean." Tippi—it had to be Tippi—descended from her stage with the grace of a dancer and the menace of an executioner. "But that's the most exclusive elevator in the city, darling. It only goes to one place."

"Where?"

"Down." Her smile widened. "In every sense of the word."

Around the room, the patrons were getting up from their various positions. They moved with the slow, deliberate grace of people who had done terrible things and enjoyed doing them.

And they all had weapons.

Stilettos. Batons. Personal massage devices that hummed with more than soothing vibrations.

"Kewpie warned me about you," Tippi said, advancing. "Said you might follow the redhead through my establishment. Said I should make sure you... stayed."

"And what did he offer you?"

"A private session." Her tongue traced her painted lips. "Kewpie knows how to motivate his friends."

The patrons closed in.

Sonny counted. Fifteen, maybe twenty. All of them looking at him like he was the entertainment.

"Okay," he said, rolling his shoulders. "Let's dance."

CHAPTER FIFTEEN: THE BASEMENT TANGO

The first stiletto flew past his head close enough to part his hair.

Sonny ducked, rolled, came up swinging. His fist connected with a jaw, and he felt the satisfying crunch of teeth. The owner of the jaw went down, and two more took her place.

Tippi's customers fought dirty. They scratched and bit and aimed for sensitive areas with surgical precision. One woman got her arms around him from behind while another wound up with a leather paddle that had nails embedded in its surface.

Sonny threw himself backward, crushing the woman behind him against a cage, and caught the incoming paddle with his forearm. It hurt. *God*, it hurt. But the pain was clarifying, focusing.

He tore the paddle from its owner's grip and swung it in a wide arc, scattering the attackers.

"Is that all you've got?" he shouted. "Is this Kewpie's best defense?"

"Oh, darling." Tippi's voice was amused. "This is just the warm-up."

She clapped her hands, and the lights went out.

For a moment, complete darkness. Then, slowly, red bulbs flickered to life—dim, bloody, turning everything into a crimson nightmare.

And in that nightmare, things moved.

Sonny couldn't see them clearly—just shapes, shadows, figures that didn't walk so much as *slither*. They surrounded him in the darkness, their breathing the only sound.

"My best students," Tippi purred from somewhere in the red. "They've been waiting for a partner."

Hands grabbed him. Dozens of hands. They pulled him down, held him still, and he felt the cold press of metal against his throat.

A razor. Multiple razors.

"Any last words?" Tippi asked.

Sonny thought about Lucy. About her laugh, her eyes, the way she'd looked at him like he was something special.

"Yeah," he said. "Duck."

He dropped his weight, going limp, and the razors passed over his head. In the confusion, he grabbed two of the hands holding him and *twisted*, using their bodies as shields.

The razors found flesh. Screaming erupted.

Sonny was up and moving, using the chaos as cover. In the red light, he could see the elevator—an old-fashioned cage model with a manual crank—against the far wall.

Tippi stood between him and salvation.

"Impressive," she admitted. "But you'll never reach—"

He didn't let her finish.

He grabbed the nearest object—a dance pole, chrome and heavy, bolted to a portable base—and ripped it free. The base swung with it, adding momentum, and he hurled the whole assembly like a javelin.

Tippi's eyes widened.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN: TOOTH TO TAILBONE

The pole entered her mouth with surgical precision.

It didn't stop there.

Tippi's body rose with the impact, lifted off her expensive shoes, carried backward by the momentum of the throw. The pole punched through her, emerging from somewhere below her spine, a grotesque skewer that pinned her to the air.

She hung there for a moment, suspended, her eyes still wide with surprise.

Then gravity asserted itself.

She fell—but the pole didn't. It had embedded itself in the wall behind her, in the very window through which Sonny had entered.

Tippi hung like a macabre ornament, her body slowly sliding down the pole's length, her life draining out in streams that painted the floor beneath her.

The room went silent.

Sonny looked at the remaining patrons. They looked back at him.

Then they ran. Scrambled. Fled through doors he hadn't seen, through secret passages hidden behind tapestries, through any exit that didn't require getting past the man who had just turned their mistress into a kebab.

Sonny walked to the elevator.

The cage door creaked open. Inside, a brass crank waited, polished from decades of use. He stepped inside, pulled the door shut, and examined the mechanism.

One direction: Down.

He cranked.

The elevator dropped.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN: GROUND ZERO

The descent was faster than expected.

The elevator plummeted, not gradually but in a barely-controlled freefall, the crank spinning uselessly in Sonny's hands. He braced himself against the cage walls as the floors blurred past—fourth, third, second, first, and then *beyond*, into some basement level that shouldn't have existed.

The cage hit bottom with a boom that rattled his bones.

Dust billowed through the bars. Somewhere, something metal groaned and settled. The air smelled of smoke and sweat and something else—something primal, electric.

Club music. Loud enough to feel.

Sonny kicked the cage door open and stepped into Bessie's Bouncing Ballroom.

It was enormous. A converted warehouse, maybe, or an underground parking garage repurposed for pleasure. The dance floor stretched out like a battlefield, packed with bodies moving to a beat that seemed to come from everywhere at once. Strobe lights turned the dancers into jerking mannequins, their faces blank, their movements synchronized.

And at the center of it all, elevated on a platform behind a fortress of turntables and vinyl crates, was Bessie.

She was tiny—barely five feet tall, even with the massive headphones clamped over her afro. Her fingers moved across the decks with surgical precision, mixing beats, dropping bass, controlling the crowd like a puppet master with invisible strings.

Behind her, the front door beckoned. Heavy. Barred. The only exit.

Their eyes met.

Bessie's hands didn't slow. The music didn't falter. But her face—painted in theatrical makeup, all dark lips and dramatic eyeliner—twisted into something ugly.

"SECURITY!" Her voice somehow rose above the music, amplified by hidden speakers. "WE HAVE A GATE-CRASHER!"

The crowd stopped dancing.

They turned.

They advanced.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN: THE BOUNCING BALLROOM

Bouncers materialized from the crowd like sharks rising from dark water.

They were huge—each one easily three hundred pounds of muscle and malice—and they moved with the practiced coordination of a team that had done this many times before.

Sonny backed toward the elevator, but the cage was already rising, called to some other floor by an unseen hand.

Trapped.

"Kewpie sends his regards!" Bessie shouted from her platform. "He said you'd put on a good show—and I'm always looking for material!"

A record sailed through the air like a deadly Frisbee. Sonny ducked, and it shattered against the wall behind him, showering him with vinyl shards.

The bouncers closed in.

The first one swung a fist like a wrecking ball. Sonny slipped under it, drove his elbow into the man's kidney, and shoved him into the path of the second attacker. They collided, tangled, and Sonny was already moving.

The club was a maze of cocktail tables and velvet ropes. He wove between them, knocking over drinks, sending glasses flying, using the obstacles to slow his pursuers.

Another record screamed past his ear. Then another. Bessie was firing them like artillery, each disc spinning with enough force to decapitate.

"Dance, little man! *Dance!*"

Sonny grabbed a cocktail tray and used it as a shield. Two records embedded themselves in the metal, quivering like thrown knives.

He kept moving.

The crowd had cleared the dance floor, pressing against the walls, their eyes gleaming in the strobe lights. They weren't running. They were *watching*. This was the show they'd paid for.

A bouncer cut off his path. Sonny feinted left, went right, and planted his foot in the man's solar plexus. The bouncer folded but didn't fall—these were professionals—and grabbed Sonny's ankle on the way down.

They hit the floor together, grappling, rolling across the sticky dance floor. Fists connected. Knees drove into ribs. The strobes made the fight seem slower than it was, each impact frozen in a moment of brilliant white.

Sonny got his hands around the bouncer's throat and squeezed.

The man's face went purple. His struggles weakened. And finally, mercifully, he went still.

Sonny rose, gasping.

Three more bouncers stood between him and Bessie's platform.

CHAPTER NINETEEN: THE CHELSEA SMILE

The records had stopped flying.

Bessie stood at the edge of her platform, looking down at the carnage on her dance floor. Her expression was unreadable behind the war paint, but her hands had left the turntables.

"Impressive," she admitted. "Kewpie said you were tough, but I didn't believe him. Bowlers are usually soft."

"I'm full of surprises."

"Clearly." She picked up a record—a 12-inch vinyl, old and scratched—and examined it idly. "But you're still not leaving through that door. The key's in my stomach, and I don't plan on coughing it up."

Sonny looked at the remaining bouncers. They looked at him. Nobody moved.

"How about a deal?" he tried. "Let me through, and I won't destroy your club."

Bessie laughed—a sound that might have been pretty in other circumstances.

"You think I care about the club? About any of this?" She gestured at the room, the patrons, the carnage. "This is just a stage, baby. A stage for Kewpie's show. And you're the finale."

The bouncers attacked.

Sonny met them with everything he had left. His body was screaming—exhausted, battered, running on fumes and fury. But he'd come too far to stop now.

He ducked under a haymaker, countered with an uppercut that snapped a head back. Caught a knee meant for his groin and twisted the attached leg until he heard something pop. Took a punch to the ribs that might have cracked bone and kept swinging anyway.

When the last bouncer fell, Sonny was barely standing.

Bessie still hadn't moved.

"Come on, then." She dropped into a fighting stance of her own, record still in hand. "Let's finish this."

Sonny climbed the platform steps.

The fight was short.

Bessie was fast, agile, trained in ways Sonny couldn't identify. She slashed at him with the record's edge, opening cuts on his arms, his chest, his face.

But she was small. And Sonny was desperate.

He caught her wrist, twisted, and slammed the record edge-first into her open, screaming mouth.

The vinyl went in with a sound like tearing paper.

Bessie's eyes bulged. Her cheeks split, the sharp edge slicing through flesh, widening her mouth into an impossible rictus. Blood poured down her chin, soaked her outfit, pooled on the platform.

Sonny didn't stop.

He grabbed the record and *pushed*, driving it deeper, watching the vinyl disappear between her parted teeth. Her screams became gurgles. Her gurgles became silence.

He pulled the record out. Her mouth—if it could still be called that—gaped from ear to ear, a Chelsea smile rendered in flesh and bone.

Sonny stomped on her back.

Her body folded. He grabbed her—fingers finding sockets, thumb hooking navel—and lifted her like a bowling ball.

The crowd watched in silent horror.

Sonny wound up. Aimed at the glass front doors.

And released.

CHAPTER TWENTY: STRIKE

Bessie hit the doors at terminal velocity.

The glass exploded outward, raining shards onto the sidewalk, onto the street, onto the limo that was pulling away from the curb.

Kewpie's limo.

Bessie's body bounced off the vehicle's hood, smearing it with blood, and tumbled under the wheels of a passing taxi. The crunch was audible even over the city noise.

Sonny emerged from the shattered doors in time to see Lucy's face in the limo's back window.

Their eyes met again. For one endless moment, everything else fell away—the carnage, the chaos, the impossible night.

She looked... sad.

Then the limo's tires squealed, and it rocketed away into the night.

Sonny didn't have time to think. A taxi was pulling up to the curb, attracted by the commotion. He yanked the door open, threw the driver onto the pavement, and slid behind the wheel.

"Sorry," he muttered, not sorry at all.

The engine roared. The tires screamed. And Sonny was in pursuit.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE: CHASE

The city blurred.

Sonny wove through traffic with a maniac's precision, threading the needle between buses and trucks, cutting off sedans and startling pedestrians. The limo was fast—faster than any vehicle that size had a right to be—but Sonny knew these streets.

He'd driven them for years, heading to tournaments and practice sessions, memorizing every shortcut and alley.

The limo took a hard right. Sonny followed, clipping a fire hydrant that exploded in a geyser behind him.

Left onto Fifth. Right onto Broadway. The city's grid broke down as they entered the industrial district, and the chase became a serpentine nightmare through narrow passages and blind corners.

The limo's brake lights flared. Sonny matched the deceleration, sensing a trap.

The tow truck came out of nowhere.

"Harry's Holy Haulers" was painted on the side in cheerful script. But there was nothing cheerful about the massive vehicle as it T-boned Sonny's taxi at forty miles an hour.

Metal screamed. Glass shattered. Sonny felt himself become weightless as the taxi spun, flipped, and tumbled through space.

He crashed through a wall.

And landed in hell.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO: HARRY'S HOLY HAULERS

The hangar smelled like oil and old blood.

Sonny pulled himself from the wreckage of the taxi, every bone in his body screaming protest. The crash had deposited him in the center of what appeared to be an automotive graveyard—dozens of vehicles in various states of dismemberment, their parts scattered across the concrete floor like puzzle pieces.

A chop shop. Professional grade.

"Well, well, well." A voice echoed from the shadows. "Looks like we've got ourselves a walk-in."

Harry emerged from behind a stack of stripped engines. He was short, stocky, with a mustache that curled at the ends and hands that looked like they could crack walnuts—or necks—with equal ease.

"Harry," the man introduced himself. "But everyone calls me Snub. You know why?"

"Enlighten me."

"Because I snub their noses. Right off their faces." He smiled, revealing gold teeth filed to points. "Before I part out the rest."

The mechanics materialized from the darkness. Dozens of them, wielding pipe wrenches and jack handles and things that had probably started as automotive tools before being modified for more creative purposes.

"Kewpie called ahead," Harry continued. "Said you might survive the crash. Said if you did, I should make sure you don't survive anything else."

Sonny looked around. The hangar doors were closed. The windows were blacked out. The only light came from work lamps scattered among the vehicular corpses.

"How much is he paying you?"

"Enough." Harry lifted a socket wrench, tested its weight. "Enough to buy new equipment. New cars. New... volunteers for the shop."

"And if I offered double?"

"Then I'd take double." Harry's smile widened. "And still kill you. Some things money can't buy, friend. Like loyalty. And the pleasure of a good dismantling."

The mechanics closed in.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE: PART BY PART

Sonny grabbed the first thing he could find—a car door, still attached to a length of frame—and swung it like a club.

The impact sent two mechanics flying and bought him three seconds of space.

He used them wisely.

The chop shop was a weapon itself. Every surface held potential—loose bolts to throw, oil slicks to create, suspended engines to drop. Sonny moved through the carnage with desperate efficiency, turning the mechanics' domain against them.

A wrench whistled past his head. He caught the arm that had thrown it and broke it over his knee.

A jack handle came down toward his skull. He sidestepped, grabbed the attacker's coveralls, and threw him into an exposed engine block.

The fuel he'd noticed earlier—gallons of it, stored improperly in open containers—became his ally. He kicked over a drum and sent gasoline flowing across the floor, turning the concrete into an ice rink.

Mechanics slipped. Fell. Cracked their heads on metal and lay still.

But there were too many of them. For every one that went down, two more emerged from the shadows. Sonny was bleeding from a dozen wounds, his breath coming in ragged gasps, his body running on reserves he didn't know he had.

Harry watched from his platform, spinning the socket wrench idly, waiting for his minions to soften the target.

Sonny needed an equalizer.

He found it hanging on the wall: a tow hook, attached to a winch mounted on a mobile crane. Industrial grade. Heavy enough to punch through steel.

Or flesh.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR: THE HOOK

Sonny grabbed the hook and pulled.

The cable unspooled behind him as he charged toward Harry's platform, cutting a path through the remaining mechanics. They grabbed at him, slowed him, but couldn't stop him—not now, not when he was this close.

Harry saw him coming. The gold-toothed smile finally faltered.

"Boys! *Boys!* Stop him!"

But the boys were scattered, broken, drowning in the gasoline-slicked chaos of their own shop.

Sonny reached the platform steps. Harry swung the socket wrench, a desperate overhead blow. Sonny caught it on his forearm—felt bone crack, didn't care—and drove the tow hook into Harry's chest.

It punched through sternum, through lung, through muscle and bone, and emerged from Harry's back in a spray of red.

The mechanic's eyes went wide. His mouth opened and closed, trying to find words, finding only blood.

Sonny reached for the winch control.

"You should have asked for triple," he said.

He pulled the lever.

The winch roared to life, pulling the cable taut. Harry's body jerked as the hook—and the cable attached to it—began to wind back.

But the cable didn't just pull. It *wrapped*.

Harry spun on the hook like a top, the cable coiling around him with each rotation. Faster and faster, the metal biting into his flesh, compressing him, the loops tightening until they began to cut.

Sonny watched.

The spiral of cable reached critical mass. Harry's body, wound tight as a spring, began to come apart.

One loop. Two. Three.

And then, with a sound like wet ripping, the cable sliced through him entirely.

Harry fell in sections. Perfect discs of meat and bone, each one a cross-section of human anatomy, stacked like fresh steaks on the platform.

Sonny stepped over the remains and headed for the back door.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE: IVY'S WHARF

The hangar's back exit opened onto a world of salt and shadow.

The wharf stretched out before him, a maze of shipping containers stacked three and four high, creating corridors of rusted metal that caught the moonlight in strange ways. Between the containers, luxury cars gleamed—Bentleys and Rolls-Royces and things with foreign names and impossible price tags.

Imports. Ivy's specialty.

Sonny moved through the maze carefully. The darkness was absolute between the container walls, broken only by occasional streetlights that created pools of pale illumination. Perfect for ambush. Perfect for murder.

He was expected.

The first lamp came out of nowhere.

It exploded at his feet, raining Tiffany glass across the concrete. Sonny rolled behind a container as two more followed, shattering against the metal where he'd been standing.

"Welcome to my collection!" A woman's voice floated down from somewhere above. "I've been expecting you, bowler boy!"

Ivy's crow's nest. He could see it now—a tower of shipping containers welded together, rising like a lighthouse above the wharf. At the top, a figure moved against the stars.

"Kewpie told me all about you," Ivy continued. "Said you were persistent. Said you had stamina. I respect that in a man."

Another lamp plummeted. Sonny dodged.

"But persistence has its limits. And you, my dear, have reached yours."

He began to climb.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX: ILLUMINATED

The tower was unstable.

Each container shifted beneath Sonny's weight, the welds groaning in protest. He climbed hand over hand, using the container ridges as handholds, dodging the antique lamps that Ivy hurled with increasingly desperate accuracy.

A Handel lamp exploded near his head. A Pairpoint shattered against his shoulder. A Steuben—worth more than his car—missed him by inches and detonated on the container below.

"Why do you keep coming?" Ivy screamed from above. "What is she to you? Just a woman! There are millions of women!"

"Not like her," Sonny grunted, pulling himself higher.

"You're a fool! A romantic fool! Don't you understand? She went with Kewpie *willingly*! She chose him! Chose his money, his power, his *future*!"

Sonny's hand found the top edge of the tower. He heaved himself over.

Ivy stood at the center of her crow's nest, surrounded by crates of priceless glass. She was older than he'd expected—sixties, maybe seventies—but elegant in a severe way. Her gray hair was pulled back tight, and her eyes glittered with intelligence and madness in equal measure.

"It's too late," she said. "Kewpie's yacht left an hour ago. He's beyond your reach now. She's beyond your reach. You've failed."

Sonny looked at the harbor below. Ships of all sizes rocked in the water, their lights reflecting off the black surface.

One of them was shaped like a bowling pin.

"I don't think so," he said.

Ivy lunged for the nearest lamp—a Tiffany masterpiece, all dragonflies and colored glass—and swung it at his head.

He caught it. Pulled it from her grip. And with a single, savage motion, shoved it down her throat.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN: GET LIT

Ivy's eyes bulged as the lamp's base forced its way past her teeth.

Sonny didn't stop. He pushed deeper, forcing the heavy base down into her chest, tearing through tissue and organ with mechanical efficiency. His arm disappeared up to the elbow.

His fingers found the cord.

He grabbed it and *pulled*.

The lamp's power cord ripped through Ivy's insides, trailing coils of intestine and gore, emerging from between her legs in a bloody parody of birth.

Sonny grabbed a Tiffany lampshade from a nearby crate—all purple wisteria and bronze edging—and jammed it onto Ivy's head.

Then he found the outlet.

It was ancient, a relic from when this crow's nest had been wired for actual light. But it was functional.

Sonny shoved the plug home.

Electricity surged through the circuit. Through the cord. Through Ivy.

She convulsed, the lampshade on her head flickering to life in a grotesque display. Her teeth cracked from the voltage. Her eyes burst in their sockets. Smoke poured from every orifice as her insides cooked.

The transformer blew after thirty seconds, cutting the power.

Ivy crumpled, still smoldering, the lampshade casting a soft purple glow across her charred remains.

Sonny walked to the edge of the crow's nest and looked out at the harbor. Kewpie's yacht—the *Kicking Klipper*, according to the letters painted on its hull—was pulling away from the dock.

But not fast enough.

Sonny grabbed a mooring rope and swung.

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT: KEWPIE'S KICKING KLIPPER

He hit the deck rolling.

The yacht was massive—a floating palace of mahogany and brass, all art deco lines and ostentatious wealth. The deck was set up like a bowling alley, with actual lanes running the length of the ship, polished wood gleaming under strings of fairy lights.

This was Kewpie's secret. His edge. He practiced out here, on the rolling waves, developing a balance and precision that no land-bound bowler could match.

Sonny was almost impressed.

"INTRUDER!"

The crew descended.

They came in waves—deck hands and security, waiters and musicians, all of them armed with pins and shoes and balls and anything else that could be weaponized. They fought with the desperation of men whose boss did not tolerate failure.

Sonny fought with the desperation of a man who had nothing left to lose.

He caught a bowling ball mid-throw and sent it back at twice the speed. It caved in the thrower's chest.

He grabbed a pin from a fallen crewman and wielded it like a club, cracking skulls and shattering bones.

He slipped in spilled champagne and used the momentum to slide between the legs of an attacker, coming up behind him and snapping his neck before he could turn.

The yacht rocked beneath him, adding a new dimension to the combat. Every step was a calculation, every swing adjusted for the ship's sway.

By the time he reached the mechanical room door, he was covered in blood—most of it not his own.

The door was locked.

Sonny kicked it open.

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE: FINAL BOSS

Kewpie looked smaller in person.

He stood at the center of his engine room, surrounded by the mechanical heart of his floating kingdom. His slicked-back hair was impeccable. His diamond pinky ring caught the emergency lights. His smile was the smile of a man who had never lost anything he wanted to keep.

"Sonny," Kewpie said. "The man who wouldn't quit. I have to admit, I'm impressed. I really thought Bertie would stop you. Or Charlie. Or *any* of the others."

"They tried."

"And failed. Spectacularly, if my sources are correct." Kewpie's eyes flickered to the carnage visible through the doorway. "Just as my crew has failed. Tell me, Sonny—was it worth it? All this death? All this destruction? For a woman who doesn't even love you?"

Sonny's hands curled into fists.

"Lucy—"

"Lucy is upstairs. In my bedroom. She went there willingly, Sonny. She saw you bowl, and she saw *me* bowl, and she made her choice. She always chooses the winner. That's who she is. That's who she'll always be."

"You're lying."

"Am I?" Kewpie spread his hands. "Look around you. Look at everything I've built. The empire. The yacht. The *legacy*. What have you built, Sonny? A reputation? Some trophies? A skill set that involves knocking down pins?"

He began to circle, and Sonny circled with him. Two predators, sizing each other up.

"I offer her the world. You offer her... what? A studio apartment? A used car? Love?" Kewpie laughed. "Love doesn't pay the bills, friend. Love doesn't buy yachts."

"But it does this," Sonny said.

And attacked.

CHAPTER THIRTY: THREE HUNDRED

The fight was unlike anything Sonny had experienced.

Kewpie was good. *Frighteningly* good. His years of practice on the rolling deck had given him a balance that bordered on supernatural. He moved like water, flowing around Sonny's attacks, countering with precise strikes that accumulated damage.

They traded blows. Grappled. Broke apart and circled again.

Kewpie's fist caught Sonny's jaw. Sonny's elbow found Kewpie's ribs. They fell together, rolled across the engine room floor, came up facing each other again.

"You can't win," Kewpie gasped. "I've trained for this. I've prepared for this. I knew you'd come, Sonny. I *wanted* you to come. This is my ultimate victory—not just taking your girl, but breaking you in front of her."

Through the ceiling, Sonny could hear footsteps. Lucy was up there. Watching, maybe. Waiting.

For what?

His hand found something on the floor. Hard. Smooth. Spherical.

A bowling ball.

Sonny's fingers slid into the holes like they'd been made for him.

"You want to talk about bowling?" he said. "Let's talk about bowling."

He swung.

The ball connected with Kewpie's temple, and the champion went down.

But Sonny wasn't done.

He reached for his bag—still strapped to his back, still holding his equipment—and pulled out his weapon of last resort.

The ball launcher.

It was homemade, cobbled together from parts he'd collected over years of touring. A bowling ball return mechanism modified into something far more dangerous. He'd never used it. Had hoped he'd never have to.

He shoved it into Kewpie's mouth.

"This is for Lucy," he said.

And pulled the trigger.

CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE: THE EXPLOSION

Bowling balls fired.

One after another, force-fed into Kewpie's gullet, pushing their way down his throat and into his body. His eyes bulged. His stomach distended. The twelve-pound projectiles filled him like a grotesque balloon, stretching skin and muscle and bone beyond all natural limits.

Sonny kept firing.

Kewpie's arms and legs spread outward, pushed by the pressure building inside him. His face went purple, then black. His body swelled to inhuman proportions—the size of a beach ball, then a car, then something even larger.

From above, through the ceiling, Sonny heard a scream.

Lucy.

He looked up—and she was there, watching through a glass floor he hadn't noticed. Her face was a mask of horror. Her hands pressed against the glass. Her mouth moved, but no sound made it through.

Sonny looked back at Kewpie.

The man was enormous now. A human-shaped balloon of flesh, barely recognizable, still somehow alive despite everything physics and biology insisted.

The pressure had to go somewhere.

Sonny released the trigger.

Kewpie exploded.

The detonation painted the engine room in red. Pieces of the former bowling champion flew in every direction, splattering against walls and machinery and the glass ceiling through which Lucy watched.

When it was over, Sonny stood in the center of the carnage, covered head to toe in what had once been his rival.

He looked up at Lucy.

She was sobbing. Hysterically. Uncontrollably.

She ran.

CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO: THE ENDING YOU PROBABLY EARNED

Sonny chased her.

Through room after room of Kewpie's floating palace, past beds with silk sheets and chairs with leather straps, past mirrors on ceilings and devices he couldn't identify and didn't want to. The yacht was a labyrinth of excess, and Lucy knew it better than he did.

She was always one room ahead. One door closing as he opened the last.

His pace slowed.

The adrenaline was fading. The injuries were catching up. Every step cost him something, and he was running out of currency.

But he kept moving.

Room after room. Horror after horror. The accumulated debauchery of a man with too much money and too little soul.

Finally, a door. The last door. He could smell salt water on the other side.

Sonny pushed through.

The back deck of the yacht opened onto the endless black of the ocean. Stars wheeled overhead, indifferent to human drama. The city was a smear of light on the distant shore.

And there was Lucy.

She stood at the railing, red hair whipping in the wind, looking not at him but at a small fishing boat that had pulled alongside the yacht. The engine pattered quietly. A rope ladder dangled over the side.

"Lucy."

She turned. Her face was streaked with tears and Kewpie's blood.

"Sonny."

It wasn't a greeting. It was... something else. Disappointment, maybe. Or resignation.

"I came for you," he said. "I fought my way through the whole goddamn city. I killed... I don't even know how many people. For *you*."

"I know." She took a step toward the ladder. "I watched some of it. Heard about the rest."

"Then come home with me. Let's... let's start over. Forget tonight. Forget everything."

She laughed. It wasn't her usual laugh—the bright, bubbling sound that had made him fall in love. This was hollow. Exhausted.

"Forget?" she said. "Sonny, you just *exploded* a man. In front of me. You turned him into... into confetti. And you think we can just *forget*?"

"I did it for you."

"I didn't ask you to."

The words hung in the air between them. The boat's engine coughed. The ocean slapped against the hull.

"You went with him," Sonny said. "You chose him."

"I never asked you to save me, Sonny." Lucy's voice cracked. "I never *needed* saving. I was making a *choice*. Maybe it was the wrong one, maybe I would have come back, maybe I was just... testing, seeing if you were what I wanted." She gestured at him—at the blood, the wounds, the madness written across his body. "But now I know exactly what you are."

"I'm the man who loves you."

"You're the man who destroyed a city for his pride." She shook her head slowly. "That's not love. That's possession."

"And now?"

"Now?" She looked at him—really looked—taking in everything he'd become. "Now I'm scared of *you*."

She grabbed the ladder.

"Lucy, wait—"

"Goodbye, Sonny. I hope the trophy was worth it."

She climbed down. The fishing boat's engine revved. And slowly, impossibly, the gap between them widened.

Sonny watched.

He watched as Lucy's silhouette grew smaller against the waves. He watched as her red hair disappeared into the darkness. He watched as the sound of the boat faded, replaced by the quiet hum of Kewpie's empty yacht.

He watched until there was nothing left to watch.

Then he sank to his knees on the blood-spattered deck.

His ball-shining towel—his companion through every battle, every impossible moment—slipped from his fingers. It fell, caught the wind for a moment like it was trying to fly, and then dropped into the black water below. The sea swallowed it without a sound.

The city glittered in the distance, indifferent to his pain.

The ocean stretched endlessly, promising nothing.

And somewhere, carried on the wind, he thought he heard her sobbing.

But maybe that was just the waves.

"I just wanted to be the one she chose," he whispered to no one.

The lanes stay empty.

THE END

A love letter to classic side-scrolling beat-em-ups and the golden age of cinema's strangest stars.

EPILOGUE: THE MORNING AFTER

The yacht drifted into port at dawn.

Harbor patrol found Sonny on the deck, unconscious but alive, surrounded by the detritus of his war. The official report would list Kewpie as "missing, presumed dead"—the polite fiction that saved everyone embarrassing questions.

The city didn't mourn.

Kewpie had owned too many people, pulled too many strings, left too many bodies in his wake. His death—whatever form it had taken—was greeted with quiet relief by those who'd lived under his shadow.

The yacht was impounded. The empire was dismantled. The bowling pin limo disappeared into police evidence, never to be seen again.

And Sonny?

Sonny went back to bowling.

What else was there? The lanes didn't judge. The pins didn't ask questions. The smooth weight of a ball in his hands was the only peace he'd ever really known.

He never saw Lucy again.

Sometimes, late at night, he'd hear about her—a rumor here, a sighting there. She'd moved to the coast, someone said. Started a new life under a new name. Maybe she was happy. Maybe she was still running.

Maybe it didn't matter anymore.

The championship that year went to someone else. A young kid with fast hands and no history, who didn't know what it cost to reach the top.

Sonny didn't care.

He'd learned something that night, fighting his way through Kewpie's kingdom of sin and shadow. Something about love, and violence, and the thin line between hero and monster.

He'd crossed that line.

And some crossings, you don't come back from.

The lanes at Bertie's Bustling Bubbles were never rebuilt. The city razed the building and put up a parking lot, as cities do. But sometimes, late at night, you can still hear the echo of pins falling and the distant, fading ghost of a woman's laugh.

Some say it's haunted.

Some say it's just the wind.

But Sonny knows better.

Sonny always knew better.

FIN

BACK COVER

"A blood-soaked valentine written in broken glass and spilled champagne."

New Year's Eve. Confetti in the air. Her hand in yours.

You're Sonny—pro bowler, tournament hopeful, and tonight, the luckiest guy at Bertie's Bustling Bubbles. Lucy's laughing at your jokes. The champagne's flowing. Midnight's coming and everything's perfect.

Then the bartender whispers something in her ear.

And she's gone.

One door. One giggle. One glimpse of a bowling-pin limo pulling away into the night.

She keeps running. You keep following.

Through eight levels of urban hell—from dive bars to dance studios, from rooftop chases to the deck of a madman's yacht—Sonny will fight an army of killers for the woman he loves. His weapons: a ball-shining towel, a pair of fists, and the kind of stubborn devotion that turns men into monsters.

But Lucy isn't a princess waiting to be saved.

And Sonny isn't the hero he thinks he is.

SONNY'S SHINING is a pulp-noir tragedy about love, violence, and the terrible things we do in the name of both. It's a beat-em-up fever dream. A romance written in blood. A story about a man who destroyed everything to win back a woman who never asked to be won.

Some games aren't meant to be played.

Some victories aren't worth the cost.

And some lanes stay empty forever.

"What happens when you cross Streets of Rage with Double Indemnity and set it on fire? You get this beautiful, brutal nightmare of a book."

"I couldn't stop reading. I couldn't stop cringing. I couldn't stop cheering. And when it was over, I just sat there, staring at the wall, wondering what the hell I'd just experienced."

"The most romantic tragedy—or tragic romance—I've read in years. Sonny deserved better. So did Lucy. Neither of them got it."